

POLITICAL EXPEDITION

While chasing her Civil Services dream in 1977, at that time 21-year-old, Mayawati met Kanshi Ram, who was running BAMSEF, an employees' federation. She was instantly drawn by his appeal for Dalit pride. Kanshi Ram first heard of Mayawati when she was a school teacher who made one of the boldest and fearless speeches ever by a Dalit at Delhi's Constitution Club. That evening, Kanshi Ram visited her and convinced her into joining the political movement and, thus, the mentor-protégé relationship was built. Later, in 1984, Kanshi Ram launched the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and Mayawati was in step with her mentor. Shortly after, she made a career shift and entered politics full time. The dream of a Dalit Consolidation became a reality on June 3, 1995, when she took over as the first Dalit Chief Minister of UP, India's most populous state. Her political journey had finally begun. A new political alliance was formed which resulted in a unique government formation in 1997 under an agreement that both parties would have its own Chief Minister by rotation for six months each. Under the deal, she was sworn in as the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh for the second time on March 21, 1997. Her third stint as Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister commenced on May 3, 2002 but unfortunately ended on July 25, 2003. On May 13 in 2007, she became the Chief Minister for the fourth time. It shows that our political system still rewards political talent and passion.

AN ICON OF WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

Mayawati has debuted on the Forbes magazine list of the most powerful women in the world. While Sonia Gandhi has slipped from her previous year's sixth position to 21st this year, Mayawati is at 59th. The magazine described Mayawati as, "the one in the running to be Prime Minister, having become Chief Minister of UP at a young age of 39, in 1995." She is a rising star and is strongly challenging Sonia Gandhi's position as the country's most powerful woman.

SYMBOL OF DIGNITY

Mayawati's much publicised agenda aims at social justice through government policies and better law and order to protect weaker sections. She believes in creating opportunities of employment instead of distributing money to unemployed; her slogan is to make Uttar Pradesh into an Uttam (excellent) Pradesh with her policies aimed at "Sarvjan Hitay - Sarvjan Sukhay". It is relevant to note that Mayawati has never used her Dalit individuality to sway her voters. She has always spoken about her policies and plans for the advancement of Uttar Pradesh. She has been inclined on using the political power for social progress. She has never trusted the chaotic or confused ways of politics. It is evident by the fact that in her more than 30 years of political career, she has never been behind the bars!

Be it the cracking down of criminals or taking action for irregularities in recruitments done during previous Regime, proposing the construction of the country's longest 1,000 km expressway between Balia and Delhi, implementation of VAT in Uttar Pradesh, ordering the arrests of organised crime heads. She did not even hesitate to take strictest action against her own party men if they were found at fault including MP's, MLA's and even Ministers. Mayawati has done it all; thus, declaring that there would not be any interference in the routine work of the police. Political Symbolism characterizes her governing of UP.

Mayawati has demonstrated all the qualities to be the future Prime Minister of India — a keen sight, a zeal for correction, an absolute integrity and a perspective to use political power for social progress. Her being elected as the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh for the fourth time says it all. She has created history by rising so high on her own. Mayawati and her party - the BSP, have adopted different strategies unlike the other ruling parties like the BJP, Congress or Left Parties. Her masterstroke was to introduce the concept of 'social engineering' which developed a new connection between the Dalits and the Brahmins. "The Chief Minister is one of us. We are not scared of police or anyone else. We live freely now," said Raj Kumar, a sweeper from a lower class.

Realising that the alignment with the upper classes is essential for her to acquire

a large mandate, Mayawati decided to adopt policies regarding reservations based on poverty instead of caste. As a result, her victory as the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh for the fourth time had exhilarated not only the Dalits but also the upper-caste Brahmins.

Mayawati has also begun articulating the party's standpoint on issues of national importance, be it the India-U.S. nuclear deal or attacks against north Indians in Maharashtra, on which she wrote to the Prime Minister.

BLUEPRINT OF PROGRESS

Another noticeable attribute of Mayawati is her resourcefulness. Her government has successfully managed finances of the state to raise extra resources to start new development schemes. Some of these schemes are Mahamaya Garib Balika Ashirwad Yojana, the Savitribai Phule Balika Shiksha Madad Yojna and the Manyawar Kanshiram ji shahri gareeb awas yojna (where houses are being houses given free of cost to the poorest of the poor). This year, the government has also launched a host of new projects which include construction of new roads and highways in the state. Her Government is spending more than 13000 Cr. for improvement of urban infrastructure in the state. Her government has also targeted to provide 24 hrs power supply to its citizen by 2012.

In the Mahamaya Garib Balika Ashirwad Yojana, the government would be depositing Rs. 20,000 in a fixed deposit account for all poor girls born on or after January 15, 2009. "Once a girl turns 18, she will get a financial aid of Rs 1 lakh, provided the beneficiary is not married," Mayawati said. "This scheme will help the government amend the asymmetric gender ratio in the state," she added.

In another scheme, the Savitribai Phule Balika Shiksha Madad Yojna, the government would be giving monetary support of Rs. 25,000 to girls coming from poor families to pursue their secondary education. "The Center has no role to play in this: the entire cost for these two schemes which is around Rs. 2,000 crore will be borne by the state", she claimed.

The Sarvjan Hitay Gareeb (slum area) malikana haq Yojna provides for ownership rights to the slim dwellers almost free of cost. More than 25000 families have been benefited in the urban areas.

ADVANCEMENT OF PILGRIM TOWNS

Development works have been initiated in Varanasi, Kannauj, Mathura, Vrindavan, Ayodhya, Prayaag and many other towns in UP. Mayawati has laid the foundation of a slew of urban development projects in the pilgrim towns of UP — Mathura and Varanasi, Kannauj. "These towns would be developed into an international heritage with new flyovers, better highways and roads," said Mayawati. She further added, "Special emphasis has been laid on the development of power sector, world-class road network, urban rejuvenation and efficient transport system." She has announced a package of Rs. 250 crore for Mathura, Rs. 800 crore for Varanasi, Rs. 1000 crore for Allahabad, Rs. 2500 crore for Lucknow, Rs. 800 crore for Kanpur and Bithoor and Rs. 148 crore for Kannauj. This was despite the fact Rs. 80,000 crore package demanded by the state was denied to the state by the center.

- We shall not enrich the Capitalists, but serve to bring a smile to the poorest of the poor in the remotest corners of India; at the same time my party is trying to bring social engineering with the help of the upper castes, since their support is quite necessary to achieve social justice in India.
- I promise to reserve places in education and employment across the board for religious minorities and the economically disadvantaged if my party came to power at the national level.
- We cannot fight just as Dalits. I understand for centuries people have fought each other. It is not easy to bring them together. But we have done this in UP.

Her relative youth (at 53), being much younger than many top Indian politicians, has added to her freshness. Mayawati is indeed one politician in India's political landscape today who can hold back the Congress party or the BJP to exercise control at the Centre in New Delhi with the influence of her political symbolism and social engineering.